

BNM-022

Techniques of Reporting

BLOCK 1

Basics of News

9

BLOCK 2

Reporting: Types and Tools

43

BLOCK 3

Reporting Beats-1

77

BLOCK 4

Reporting Beats-2

123

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(These units have been adapted from MJM-021 and revised. Adaptation and revision have been done by the second authors.)

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Content Page

BLOCK 1	BASICS OF NEWS	9
Unit 1	Understanding News	11
Unit 2	News Sources	22
Unit 3	News Room Set-up and Functioning of Print Media	32
BLOCK 2	REPORTING: TYPES AND TOOLS	43
Unit 4	News Reporting: Different Types	45
Unit 5	Research for Journalistic Writing	56
Unit 6	Interview: A Journalistic Tool	65
BLOCK 3	REPORTING BEATS-1	77
Unit 7	Civic Reporting	79
Unit 8	Reporting Social Issues	89
Unit 9	Reporting Lifestyle, Fashion and Films	98
Unit 10	Reporting Health and Education	110
BLOCK 4	REPORTING BEATS-2	123
Unit 11	Sports Reporting	125
Unit 12	Crime Reporting	136
Unit 13	Legal Reporting	149
Unit 14	Political Reporting	161

COURSE INTRODUCTION: TECHNIQUES OF REPORTING

Learning how to be a skilled professional and learning how to report continues to be an important arm of journalism education even to this day. This course also teaches a budding journalist the art of analysing facts in the context provided and interpreting it to make meaning for larger social good through creating awareness, educating, informing and persuading keeping the ethical standards of profession in mind.

The course **BNM-022 Techniques of Reporting** will provide you a basic understanding of concepts and principles of news reporting, the importance and art of cultivating news sources while also giving you a vivid idea of set up and operation of newsroom of various media houses. Other than this, there are three more blocks. one of which focuses on techniques of reporting and the necessary skills that go into making a credible, holistic, professional and balanced news report tastefully in a modern, technocratic news media world. The other two blocks focus on different beats of reporting, enumerating in detail what kind of specialisation a budding journalist needs to build to cover a particular beat.

Block 1 (Basics of News) introduces you to news concepts. Unit 1 defines and enumerates the principles of news and news values. Unit 2 Talks in detail about the news sources, their kinds, how to cultivate them and ethical practices and Unit 3 discusses at length the news room set up and functions of print media.

Block 2 (Reporting: Types and Tools) explains the reporting techniques in detail. Unit 4 details the different types of news reporting and what sets one apart from the other. Unit 5 stresses a very important aspect of research for journalistic writings and how it adds credibility and background information to any news story and Unit 6 speaks about the tools and techniques used for interviews.

Block 3 is Reporting Beats-1 and covers four different beats. Unit 7 describes civic reporting at length and citizen journalism-a concept that has come up fast over the last decade.. Unit 8 focuses on reporting social issues. Unit 9 will tell you about the interesting world of lifestyle, fashion and film reporting and Unit 10 will give you an insight of health and education reporting.

Block 4 is titled as Reporting Beats -2 and has four units. Unit 11 is a detailed account of sports reporting. Unit 12 talks about crime reporting. Unit 13 teaches you how to report legal matters while staying within the purview of the law and the last Unit 14 focuses on the different aspects of political reporting.

On completion of this four credit course, you should be able to:

- describe the concepts, principles and sources of news;
- explain different types of reporting techniques;

- undertake civic, crime, sports and legal reporting; and
- report social issues, health, education and lifestyle.

This course is designed to make you skilled in theoretical aspects and their applicability while reporting news for media houses and also to hone the skills of those who maybe apt at a few things but lack holistic knowledge about news reporting and make them ready for the competitive world of news reporting.



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BLOCK 1
BASICS OF NEWS

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UNIT 1 UNDERSTANDING NEWS

Structure

- 1.0 Introduction
- 1.1 Learning Outcomes
- 1.2 What comprises of News?
- 1.3 Elements of News
- 1.4 News Writing : Principles and Techniques
 - 1.4.1 5Ws and 1H
 - 1.4.2 The Inverted Pyramid
 - 1.4.3 Use of the Inverted Pyramid
 - 1.4.4 Inverted Pyramid: A Critique
- 1.5 Conclusion
- 1.6 Further Readings
- 1.7 Check Your Progress

1.0 INTRODUCTION

We as human beings have an inbound curiosity as to the events taking place around us and the general know-how of the world order. Everyone is eager to know the what, who, where, when, and how of the events and incidents taking place. In addition, the curiosity of the future awaits every individual. In case the events and incidents are of recent occurrence, and are of interest to a vast majority of people, it becomes all the more significant and necessary for them to look for further information about these events. By mending together the specifics of all the materials, some concrete, some blurred and quite often valuable facts emerge. Whatever materializes from such information is often critical and people need to know these and all possible details about these. Such type of information, therefore, is called “NEWS”. The outline of the latest events or any useful yet unknown information falls under the spectrum of news. In this unit we shall systematically define ‘news’ and provide you with all the necessary perspectives on news.

1.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After you have gone through this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the concepts and definitions of news;
- describe the principal elements of news and news writing; and
- examine various news writing techniques.

1.2 WHAT COMPRISES OF NEWS

It is said that news is difficult to define. However, news remains something that surprises the reader, listener and viewer, and will always remain so. Let us look at some of its definitions:

- Most dictionaries impart the meaning of 'news' as "an account of a recent event, or information that's not known previously."
- According to the Random House Dictionary of English Language, the meaning of 'news' is: "a report of a recent event; intelligence, information."
- The Oxford Dictionary says: News is the report of recent events, or occurrences brought or coming to one as new information; new occurrences as a subject of report or talk."
- Any important information coming from North, East, West and South, which deserve to be taken as 'news'.
- Lord Northcliffe, the famous British editor, said of news: "News is something that somebody somewhere doesn't want to print, wants to suppress. All the rest is advertising."
- News is essentially about people, events, surrounding people, and places. "Get the Truth and print it," said John S. Knight, founder of a greatest
- U.S. newspaper chain, adding, news is heavy on community service, and
- society interest and mindful of the city's pecking order in civic and social affairs.
- When a dog bites man, that's not news; but when a man bites dog that's news.
- News is what affects readers directly.
- News is a timely account of a recent, interesting and significant event.
- Change. The passing of an era, old landmarks being torn down, new lifestyles replacing old, new attitudes on old questions, anniversaries of major events.
- A journalism professor of Stanford University, USA, Chilton R. Bush, defined news as "...the report of an event that a reader can and will understand."
- Another pragmatic view in defining news, says: "News is an account of an event which a newspaper prints in the belief that by so doing it will profit."

After reading the above varied definitions of news, you would have understood the broad nature and concept of news. But, it is difficult to accurately define 'news'. For, to be correctly termed as the 'News', any information must be factual, new and interesting. There must be facts to report; without facts, there can be no news. It is important that these facts must be new to the reader, listener and the viewer. Again, news is what's being published on the news pages of newspapers, and magazines, broadcast on radio and telecast on television networks, or put out on the Internet.

As William Metz, Professor of Journalism, University of Nevada, USA, says: "While it may not be possible to describe it precisely in words, every news reporter must come to a personal understanding of nature of news, must reach some conclusion about its essence before it is possible to recognise 'news' when it happens."

At this point, it's also important to know as to what we mean by 'news sense', or 'news judgment'. "Being able to identify what will interest readers is called having news sense," said a noted American professor of journalism, Wyford Hicks.

The important assertion about news, which is even somewhat contradictory is, bad news sells more newspapers than good news. So, what would be the news today? Given the limits of space, time and resources, what's important, what isn't, what's to be left in, what's to be left out? And in the age of Internet, infinity, who's to say what's news, asks Wyford Hicks.

Thus, it will not be an exaggeration to say that there are almost as many definitions of the news as there are reporters/journalists.

Activity – 1

Choose a newspaper. Make 4 boxes labelled i) Most important news of the day; ii) Sports news; iii) Entertainment; iv) Major Advertisement. Now, collect materials that fall under these four heads for a week from the same newspaper. Analyze the pattern after a week.

1.3 ELEMENTS OF NEWS

Let's now discuss the principal elements or ingredients of writing news. If you are consuming/reading a news, you would surely notice that a news item or a news story is not written in a style or fashion we write our letters or essays or any other piece of writing.

News has to be written, presented or broadcasted in such a manner or style that the reader, listener or viewer gets the most important information in the shortest possible span of time, without using excessive and redundant words. For the same purpose, there are certain established factors of a standard news story. Some of the important elements include: Timeliness, Proximity, Prominence, Dimension, Consequence, Conflict, Empathy, Adventure and Weather, among others.

Timeliness: The time of occurrence of an event is the most important element of a news story. People want to know about the event as quickly as possible. Report of an event that happened yesterday or the day before yesterday is generally deemed stale and often not considered fit for publication, unless it is of extra ordinary nature, or extremely significant in some manner.

News may cease to be news after 24 or even after 12 hours in today's age of rise in digital media. It is news because it's "new." Readers, listeners or viewers very well recognise the immediacy and perishability as vital factors in 'newsfall' and news reporting. For example,

"Rupee Plunges To All-Time Low Of 82.33 Against Dollar"

This news is relevant for a particular time period as the dollar value might change in just another hour.

Proximity: Closeness or nearness of an event or an incident to the audience has tremendous importance for reporters as well as for a newspaper. Proximity could be geographical or relevance to the audience. The more 'local' or closer the site where the event took place, the greater will be its importance to be termed as news. For example,

“Noida twin towers demolition: Noida-Greater Noida Expressway, other routes to remain closed.”

This story would naturally be on front page in all the local newspapers, but may be positioned at the inside pages of the papers in Jammu, Bhopal, Guwahati, or Surat. A local angle to the news has greater appeal and greater relevance.

Prominence: If a well-known personality happens to be involved in the event, it will invariably make news. For example, if the prime minister strains his ankle while walking to the car, or a celebrity has a bathroom fall, it makes news. The important fact is that the famous, the infamous and even the eccentric command a special appeal for audiences.

Impact: Impact stands for the impact that the news have on people and how the story affects them. If the U.S. president or British prime minister announces his plans to sanction military aid to Pakistan, it's bound to impact the Indo-US or Indo- British ties, and also Indo-Pak relations. Similarly, if the Union Government increases income tax in its annual budget, or levies a tax on purchase of cars, that makes it a national news.

Human Interest: Quite often, newspaper reporters come across situations, which induce emotions of mercy, sentiments or sympathy. For example, if a visually- challenged person performs some daring act, such as scaling Mount Everest, or a bicycle- rickshaw puller's son gets selected in IIM / IIT admission test, these are human interest stories. You may recall the incident when a four-year- old child by the name of Prince, fell in a way-side 30-feet-deep well some years ago; the rescue work by the army personnel was put out live on many television channels. This was a live human interest story which attracted the interest of viewers all over India for many hours, till the rescue act was completed.

Conflict: Conflict of any type – political, social, cultural, communal, among certain sections of society, difference of opinion among two or more political parties, conflict among some warring groups, or more of such conflicts always make news.

Adventure: As mentioned earlier, tackling difficult tasks in a swift and easy manner by individuals always make news anywhere. “Elderly women's Himalayan expedition covering 4841km concludes after 140 days at Ladakh,” stating an adventurous plus human interest story for the readers.

Novelty: Novel, rare, or unusual incidents make news.

Empathy: Often, several events mirroring tragedy, humour, oddity, victory, failure take place now and then in our life. Quite a few of these happenings attract our concern or empathy: incidents of flood, accident; a child falling

off from the arms of its mother in a moving bus/train and getting crushed under its wheels – all make news.

Weather / Climate / Environment: Weather – extreme heat, cold, rain, storm, pollution affects all of us and makes news. For example, the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami made news all over the world in so many countries, including India, as it killed nearly 230000 men, women, children, and wreaked unusual, unimaginable losses of property, animals and marine life. Climatic changes, different aspects of environment degradation, pollution as well as efforts towards environment conservation affect general public at large.

Given above are some of the most important elements, which often make news. However, there are always occasions when we find new situations arising and figuring as eminent news stories in the media all over the world.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What all is considered News? Define news with help of definitions from few authors.

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2. Out of the five most important elements of a news story, provide example from the recent news fitting the description to any two elements of news story.

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1.4 NEWS WRITING : PRINCIPLES AND TECHNIQUES

News writing is a style of writing oriented towards reporting news. As mentioned earlier, news has to be written in such a manner and drafted in a style that the main or the principal information is conveyed to the audience in minimum possible words and in short time with maximum effect. Therefore, the first paragraph of the news story, which is called Lead or Intro (introduction), tries to present the gist of the event/happening in about 24 to 30 words. We shall also briefly mention how to draft an intro/lead, and how many kinds of leads are there for writing the news.

1.4.1 5Ws and 1H

The news stories are written using 5Ws and 1H in the first paragraph itself. This is probably the first and the most important while writing a news item. The first paragraph of news, called the Intro or Lead should contain answers to five Ws and one H, namely, Who, What, When, Where, Why and How. This is the most cardinal principle of writing news and is followed all over the world. The first paragraph of the news item must clearly state as to who is the main actor, character, object, subject or concern of the event, which needs to be told or written about. Is it the President, Prime Minister, any minister, governor, a well-known foreign dignitary, or any other prominent person?

The other four Ws and one H are:

- **What** happened?
- **When** did it happen?
- **Where** did happen?
- **Why** did it happen?
- **How** did it happen?

Depending upon the nature of the event, the reporter has to decide which of these Ws is more important and crucial to the story.

The time when the event occurs is extremely significant. Any event having impact on a large majority of people will also be of great import. For example, election results make for timely news. An accident or an important event make news for its timeliness.

The venue of event also assumes great importance in a news story. For example, if the event occurs in prime minister's office, parliament house, or in state assembly, in mosque or temple, every place mentioned here has its own unique significance. Therefore, each W has its own importance in the context of the event which is reported.

Incidentally, the 5W-1H formula of writing the intro or lead is attributed to the late British author who lived and worked in India, Rudyard Kipling. He wrote for the daily English language newspaper, The Pioneer, then published from Lucknow in the 1930s. Kipling's favourite saying for writing news based on this formula was as follows:

I keep six honest serving men

They taught me all I knew

Their names are what, and why and when

And how and where and who

Given below are some examples to tell you as to how intros and leads can be drafted, based on the formula 5Ws and 1H:

WHEN: On coming Monday, August 15, at 8 a.m., the Prime Minister will address the nation on its Independence Day from the ramparts of Delhi's historic Red Fort.

WHERE: From the ramparts of Delhi's historic Red Fort, the Prime Minister will address the nation on August 15 this year, the Independence Day of the country, at 8 a.m.

WHO: Prime Minister will address the Independence Day function on Monday, August 15, at 8 a.m. from the rampart of Delhi's historic Red Fort.

WHAT: On the Independence Day, on August 15 at 8 a.m., Prime Minister will address the nation from the rampart of Delhi's historic Red Fort.

WHY: As August 15 marks the nation's Independence Day, the Prime Minister will address the nation from Delhi's historic Red Fort at 8 a.m.

HOW: From the ramparts of Delhi's historic Red Fort, Prime Minister will address the nation on August 15, which marks the Independence Day, at 8 a.m.

The reporter who has to decide which of the 5 Ws is crucial and is key and really essential to the story, and of course to its overall development. It also depends on the fact as to where is the story being written from, and where is intended to be published. The story needs to be angled to suit the local audience of the newspaper accordingly.

1.4.2 The Inverted Pyramid

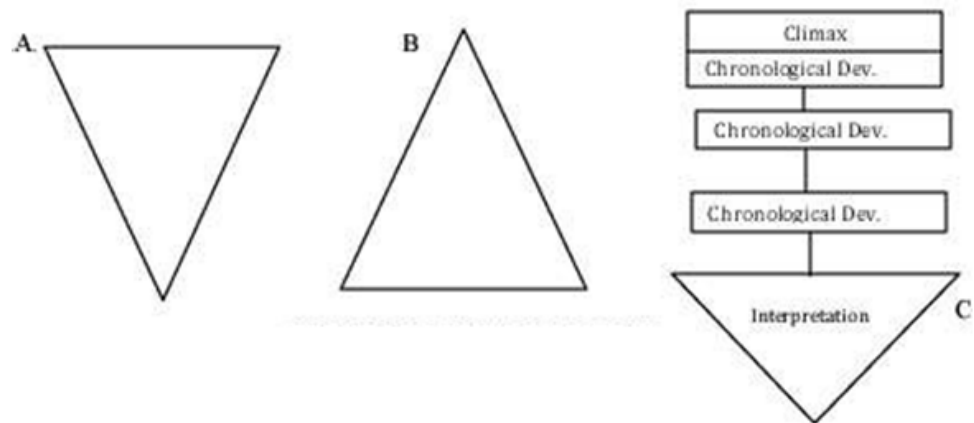
Another traditional technique of writing the news is in the form of an Inverted Pyramid. The first paragraph, i.e., the Intro or the Lead, contains the most important and main thrust of the news item. The body of the news item further expands, elaborates and explains rest of the story. Therefore, the main points stated in the Lead or the Intro have to be supported by the facts in the paragraphs that follow the Lead or the Intro.

Thus, if you view the story in the form of a figure or a diagram, it will look like an inverted pyramid as illustrated below. The most important point in the story should be at the top, followed by less important facts, with the least important ones coming at the bottom. Such a technique of writing a story is called Inverted Pyramid.

Actually, the inverted pyramid technique is a very basic method of news writing. A question may now arise in your mind as to why should one work like this? The main argument behind it is that the news theme point should be wrapped up in one-sentence, or two-paragraph nutshell, with summary high up in the story. Also known as lead or 'nutgraph'—important information near the top of the story, usually in one paragraph.

Here are some more illustrations and diagrams to tell you as to how should the news story be constructed and written. These are borrowed from a famous book entitled Exploring Journalism, written by two most well-known American professors of journalism, Roland E. Wolesely and Laurence R. Campbell.

ILLUSTRATION NO. 1 : PYRAMID



A: Illustrates the form for a routine news story as it is prepared for print. Its lead summarises the story, then the importance of information decreases gradually until the least significant material is at the end.

B: This figure is the pattern used in writing the story chronologically and is usually employed with suspended interest features. The story begins with unimportant but hugely attractive details and broadens as it nears the climax

C: This figure may be used in building a story consisting of the elements of almost equal value throughout. Most important is the lead, least so, the final details of the story.

Source: Exploring Journalism By: Roland E. Wolseley and Laurance R. Campbell .

1.4.3 Use of the Inverted Pyramid

It is believed that the inverted pyramid technique of news writing was innovated during the American civil war, some 150 years ago. Prior to that, news items were written in the form of a narrative, somewhat like a fiction or as an essay, in a chronological style, the most important point coming in the end. It was during the U.S. civil war that the news writing style went through drastic changes. This was necessitated due to the fact that the most recent development in the progress of the civil war had to be communicated, through the Morse telegraphic mode, in the first paragraph itself. And if it was put in the end of the write-up, as in the case of an essay, or any other narrative, it could be lost in transit. Therefore, to overcome that danger, war correspondents started prefixing and putting the recent most war news in the first paragraph itself, which increased the chances of the news 'arrival' or receipt at the news desk, in the beginning of the message itself. Though the original reason for employing the inverted pyramid technique of news writing has gone into oblivion, most news items are now-a-days written in this manner and style only, almost universally.

The inverted pyramid technique is also deemed to be a rational, technological and typographical outcome of modern news writing necessity for the consumers who are busy in their life's other important routines and can afford to spare very little time to go through the details of the long and

elaborate news stories. They prefer to get their news as quickly and in the minimum possible time as the news media can deliver.

This style of presenting the news facilitates the reporter to organise the facts of the story systematically and quickly. It is also convenient for the sub-editor to compose the story's headlines, and make the news pages to attract the attention of the reader. In addition, it is time-saving for the reader to decide whether s/he is interested in going through the entire text of the news story. Thus, the inverted pyramid news writing style also suits newsmen at all levels.

1.4.4 Inverted Pyramid: A Critique

Of late, some senior journalism scholars and journalists have started questioning the inverted pyramid style. According to a well-known American journalism professor and author, Christopher Passante, why should pyramid be 'inverted' when the pyramid in its pyramid shape, i.e., the right way up, can serve the purpose perfectly and most befittingly? For, anyway, the primary objective of the pyramid as such is to show that the point in a news story is made in a descending order of importance. The news is deliberately written in a manner that the reader can stop reading when s/he has just satisfied his/ her curiosity and desire to be informed about a particular event. Another implicit purpose of this style of news writing is to cut the story from bottom up without losing its important parts.

A noted critic of the inverted pyramid philosophy Professor William Metz of the University of Nevada, USA, feels that the inverted style has "over-standardised" the technique of writing news. He adds that as "it is not a natural storytelling method because its climax comes at the onset... is predictable and old-fashioned."

A former editor of the United Press International (UPI), Roger Tatarian, has pointed out that narrative news writing style leads will be more popular over summary leads, especially in "stories reader has already heard over the air."

Lately, the 'featurised' style of news writing has started gaining acceptance over the traditional and weather-beaten inverted pyramid especially in prominent American daily newspapers such as The New York Times, Washington Post, USA Today, The Wall Street Journal, The Los Angeles Times, The Chicago Tribune, etc.

As one former managing editor of The New York Times, Turner Catledge, also said about the diminishing value of 5Ws and 1 H, some time ago: "Once it will no longer be necessary, as may be, never was, to wrap up in one sentence or paragraph, all the traditional 5Ws."

Thus, there is need to caution against intensive use of the Inverted Pyramid techniques of news writing: Don't worship the pyramid: it's only a way of visualising the most common structure of a traditional news story. The guiding principle in developing a story is: what does the reader needs or wants to know?

Activity-2

Take five news stories each from newspapers and news websites. Compare their writing style. Write your observations.

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What are the pros and cons of inverted pyramid style of writing.

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1.5 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, what is news and the various elements of news have been discussed in detail. We talked about the basic principles and important techniques of news writing. We all know that the inverted pyramid style has been the most popular style for news writing. In this unit we discussed this style in detail.

1.6 FURTHER READINGS

Writing and Editing News by K.V Krishnaswamy, 2015, New Delhi : Orient Blackswan Private Limited

Associated Press Guide to News Writing: The Resource for Professional Journalists, 1999

Rene J. Cappon, Peterson's Publications, News Structure & Flow by Writer's Digest 1996, Cincinnati, Ohio.

1.7 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

Check Your Progress 1

1. News can be defined as timely reports of significant events that concern and interest majority of people. What is news means different things to different people. Moreover, the definition and concept of news varies from place to place and time to time. Chilton R. Bush, defined news as “....the report of an event that a reader can and will understand.” (Learners can add few more definitions from the unit.)
2. The five most important news elements are:
 - a. Timeliness – recent stories have more news value than older occurrences.

- b. Proximity – stories of happenings which are local are of more interest.
- c. Prominence – news about well-known people gets more attention.
- d. Impact – events which have a wide ranging affect are more newsworthy.
- e. Novelty – any occurrence which is different or new will make for more interesting news.
- d. Examples of recent news will be subject to student's understanding of any element.

Check Your Progress 2

1. Pros and cons of inverted pyramid style of writing are following:

Pros: The most important point in the story should be at the top, followed by less important facts, with the least important ones coming at the bottom.

It is a rational and technological outcome of modern news writing necessity for the consumers who are busy in their life's other important routines and can afford to spare very little time to go through the details of the long and elaborate news stories.

Cons: inverted style has “over- standardised” the technique of writing news. “it is not a natural storytelling method because its climax comes at the onset... is predictable and old-fashioned.”

UNIT 2 NEWS SOURCES

Structure

- 2.0 Introduction
- 2.1 Learning Outcomes
- 2.2 Sources of News
 - 2.2.1 Reporter
 - 2.2.2 Bureau Reports
 - 2.2.3 News Agencies
 - 2.2.4 Individual Sources
 - 2.2.5 Online sources and Social Media Platforms
- 2.3 Reliability and Credibility of Sources
- 2.4 Let Us Sum Up
- 2.5 Further Readings
- 2.6 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

2.0 INTRODUCTION

News that is filled up on pages of our newspapers or phones are made possible with the help of individuals or teams acting as sources of news. Information which is considered as “news” is collected in an organized way that involves personnel who are specifically trained to track news developments and select ‘news’ from a wide variety of events that transpire in the world around us. Needless to say, news is dependent on news sources and the news organizations’ ability to get the news out to the audience in a timely (news being a perishable commodity), reliable, and presentable manner.

News, therefore, is a complex process that involves selection of events that are deemed ‘news worthy’. This selection implies three things:

1. Acertain class of people whowe know as journalists and editors make the selection and decide what we must read as news;
2. it inherently means that certain people or sources have privileged access to media than others; and
3. it mandates a routinised functioning of the media which presents stories in a specified format and in a factory-like content production to produce news 24x7.

In this unit, we shall discuss different aspects of news sources including

- the variety of news sources available to news organizations and the social ‘construction of news’;
- the source-media relationship and
- organizational routines in media including the hierarchical distribution of work among a pool of trained reporters who use these sources to produce their daily staple of news.

The unit lists different news sources available to a news organization / reporter while differentiating between them from the point of view of journalistic routines, ethics and practices.

2.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completing this unit, you should be able to:

- describe different news sources;
- understand the usage of various sources and describe their significance in the structuring of a news report; and
- explain reliability and credibility of sources.

2.2 SOURCES OF NEWS

News sources can be people who journalists interview, talk to, quote, observe or meet to ‘construct’ a news story. They provide the basic information which is the building block of a news story. At the same time no two sources can lend the same meaning to a news story. Since the role of journalists is interpretational, framing it or mapping it in a certain social or cultural context and thus making news understandable to the audiences, the choice of one source over another is often ideological.

2.2.1 Reporters

Reporters and correspondents, as you are aware, are the backbone of any newspaper, television news channel or a news website. They are literally the face of the news organizations. In fact, today news has become so ‘reporter centric’ that news channels and newspapers market their brands in the names of their reporters.

Competent, well-known and experienced reporters are thus central to any news organisation which aspires to earn its readers’ or viewers’ trust and claim to practice high quality journalism. Reporting itself is a highly specialised and demanding profession that requires years of training and commitment to journalism. Young reporters have to sit with their editor for hours and patiently learn to report, make contacts and get skilled into the fine art and craft of reporting. They have to learn to ‘create’ a news story which follows well established conventions of the narrative form (see Schudson 1982), language codes, hierarchy of sources and seamless editing that hides the frames in which meaning of the story is contained. Graham Murdock points out how the routinised and fixed way of presenting news within familiar frameworks has two important consequences: it ‘recharges and extends the definitions and images in question’ and it also conveys the eternal continuity and stability of the social structures and order.

News gathering requires certain acumen and as they say- ‘a nose for news’. Cub reporters are usually groomed into specialised areas of news, which has resulted into what news organisations call the ‘beat system’ categorised into national, political, metro/ city, business, crime, sports, legal, science and environment, education, health, entertainment, etc. In this division of work

between beat reporters, special correspondents and the general reporters, each are trained differently. This also implies that the beat reporter has to spend plenty of time in the field, building contacts with key persons who will eventually be his/ her sources often resulting in a relationship of mutual cooperation with their sources. For example, a city crime reporter must have adequate 'contacts' in the Police department, the courts and locals who will then be his/ her informers in case some crime happens. While the reporter gets to file the story, the sources attain a proximity to the Press and get certain perks such as free publicity when quoted in the story.

As established, time is of supreme value in news. A reporter could be reprimanded for not covering an event in his/ her beat on time when other channels have already begun flashing it. Source proximity could play a crucial role in getting the information first. In a 'breaking news' culture marked by knee-jerk reactions, sensationalism and where news outlets are competing to be the first to report, the credibility and aptitude of the reporter who fails the time test is severely put under the scanner. This mad rush to be the first to 'break a story' can lead to instances of poor journalism when reporters fail to verify or cross-check what their sources are saying in the interest of time. This can also lead to a serious violation of the principle of factual reportage.

After applying satisfactory checks and balances, the reporters 'cultivate' trustworthy sources who give them information from time-to-time. Some of these include: politicians, ministries, influential individuals, government officials, social activists, spokespersons, public intellectuals and even other reporters covering the same beat in 'rival' news organisations. Gans (1979) enlists six considerations that determine the suitability of a source to a journalist. These are:

- i. past suitability
- ii. productivity
- iii. reliability
- iv. trustworthiness
- v. authoritativeness
- vi. articulateness

Fields of journalism such as investigative journalism that results in 'exclusives', requires more time and tact in the field, chasing information that is not easy to unearth. Investigative reporters develop 'contacts' who can tip-off classified information or 'leak' information in public interest to spark off a nationwide debate. Investigative reportage can also be used as an effective safeguard against attempts by governments or powerful groups to manipulate information or create consensus on issues without its full deliberations in the public domain.

The problem is that most news organisations do not have the resources or the time to let their reporters go on such investigative trails for weeks before it can come out in the form of stories (Bhushan, 2013). The breaking news ethos has in that sense eroded many long held journalistic principles of

accuracy and objectivity. The investigative news culture is fast withering away and giving place to sensationalism and entertainment oriented news. Another phenomenon that has had a far reaching impact on how news is gathered is the news organisations' reliance on freelance stringers who are paid on per news/ story basis helping cut down the expenses of retaining full time reporters (Roy, 2011) besides providing geographical proximity (Gans, 1979).

2.2.2 Bureau Reports

Reports from several bureaus across the country and abroad are an important aspect of the routine of news gathering. At the level of the bureaus, the reporters are less inundated with assignments when compared with the head offices and therefore are able to spend more time in the field. The logic behind setting up bureaus is geographical closeness- given that reporters from their own native states or region have a better understanding of the political, economic and cultural dynamics of the region and therefore are better placed to cover local news stories.

2.2.3 News Agencies

The modern form of the press is linked to the rise and consolidation of the news agencies. News agencies are a steady source of news for media outlets. Each news organisation subscribes to a large number of national and international news agencies or 'wire services' to keep a close tab on all that is happening in different parts of the world where they can neither set their own bureaus nor afford to send reporters. For example, maintaining a foreign correspondent in all the capitals of the EU throughout the year will be extremely expensive and out of reach for most newspapers, TV news channels and news websites based in New Delhi. It would also mean that they cut themselves out from news developments in these places. However, subscribing to Reuters or AP (Associated Press) would ensure a minute-by-minute update on every event that transpires in those countries with their vast network of reporters sending stories from the ground.

The rise and consolidation of news agencies

Early founders of news agencies such as Bernhard Wolff in Germany, Baron Von Reuter in England and Charles-Louis Havas in France started out just like any other business venture. They focused on regions and places where technologies of printing were available. In 1859, the big three formed a cartel or a ring virtually dividing the world into three parts for news collection: Reuters was to cover the British Empire, North America, and most of Asia and Egypt; Havas, the French Empire, the Latin countries of Europe, and South America; and Wolff, the remainder of Europe (Cuthbert, 1980).

With the expansion in industrial revolution, printing press, capitalist economies, these news agencies were organised early in the nineteenth century to quickly provide latest market reports to traders and business houses that needed them. There have been considerable shifts in the ownership patterns of news agencies from initial days of private ownership to the post World War period when it was realised that the news agencies

should be owned by newspapers subscribing to their services and not by individuals.

Soon after World War II, when most countries in Asia gained freedom from colonial rule many national news agencies were set up. As news agencies grew and expanded their potential for quick transmission of political news and information between different countries became apparent as was also realised that they could provide a bulk of information to newspapers. This made the business of news agencies very lucrative as many newspapers wanted to report about events from places where their correspondents could not be sent due to economic reasons.

The birth of the Associated Press can be attributed to attempts to break the European cartel and partly stemming from cultural and ideological reasons to reduce the control of the cartels over news flow. By 1859, the AP was able to reorganise its business in the American region to get a near exclusive hold of the American territory signing a contract with the European cartel that each agency should create the news report in its own marked territory and provide it for the use of the other contracting agencies.

Reuters was the first news agency to set operation in India in fact Asia, from Mumbai in 1886, it expanded its operations to other countries under the British rule. The opening of the Suez Canal and installation of a direct cable link between London and the East made a major difference in the speed with which messages could be transmitted. Reuter and its subsidiary agency, the Associated Press of India, had a monopoly in India until the Press Trust of India was formed by the Indian newspapers.

Press Trust of India (PTI) was incorporated on August 27, 1947 under the Indian Companies Act 1913. The story of the growth and evolution of PTI which is the largest news agency of the country is itself a saga of the growth of journalism in India (Raghavan, 1987). The PTI has an extensive news collection and distribution system in the country. Collectively, they put out more than 2,000 stories and 200 photographs a day to feed the expansive appetite of the diverse subscribers, who include the mainstream media, the specialized presses, research groups, companies, and government and non- governmental organisations.

What happened in the U.S. in the 1920s was repeated in the 1970s, this time by the developing countries who found that under the monopoly control of the western news agencies the developing world could neither get fair access to news (being always under-reported) nor would it be represented justifiably. These countries felt that only negative news about disasters, under development, poverty, malnutrition and other problems in their part of the world would be considered newsworthy by the western media. As a result, the 1970s were impregnated by widespread rejection and protests against the international news flow imbalance between the core and the periphery (Hamelink, 1990).

This was also the time marked by UNESCO's free flow ideology which assumed that individual information access as supreme and a fundamental human right. The doctrine evolved from two UN declarations: first, 1946 UN

Declaration on Freedom of Information which placed much significance to free flow of information between countries and second, the UN Declaration on the Universal Declaration of Human Rights which looked upon freedom of information as a fundamental human right as evident from the Article 19 of the declaration.

By the mid-1970s there was a growing demand for democratisation of information particularly from the Third World countries most of which got organised under the umbrella of the New World Information and Communication Order (NWICO), which called for a 'new order' as a move away from the 'old order' of information imperialism. All through the MacBride roundtables (culminating in the significant report, *Many Voices, One World*) which were commissioned by the UNESCO to address the North-South information imbalance, among a host of other disparities, as voiced by scholars and media persons in Asia, Africa and Latin America, there was a need to reduce the vertical, one-way flow of news and rely on local, indigenous sources including establishment of more regional news agencies.

Using Agencies' Content

Let us now see how the news organisations use these wire services or the wire copies to make news. Since the news agencies have to cater to many nations who might have different stakes and interests in given news situation, the 'copy' made by them is mostly an objective statement of the facts as they occurred with minimum interpretation or commentary. The input department has several trainees at the desk and reporters who monitor at least 4-5 international and national news agency updates all the time to alert the news desk or the editorial if something significant happens. It is then taken up, 'cleaned', or more inputs added to it and readied to be placed in the bulletin or the newspaper. News agency copies are considered to be reliable and extremely authentic sources of news so the newspapers don't have to bother about checking the facts and usually tend to attribute the agency whose news is sourced.

Television channels subscribe to the audio-visual footage like by APTN and ANI in India which is sent along with the story and use the clips for their stories. For example, the Turkey-Syria earthquakes that took place in February 2023 are procured from the clips sent by the wires and could be edited together to produce one complete news package of how the earthquakes looked like, since it is not possible or cost effective to send an organization's own reporters to the multiple disaster locations.

On the other hand, in the case of domestic coverage or news that occurs in India, a news organisation would have the advantage of subscribing to copies from the PTI, ANI, Univarta, and other news agencies in the country and also would be able to send one's own reporters who could reach the location in a few hours to provide live coverage. Generally, in case of important news stories, news organisations use wire copies as a buffer for the time their own reporters take to reach the location. Besides, reporters provide first-hand accounts of what is happening, meet eye witnesses and create several stories around that one event making it exclusive to that newspaper or channel. It is

this, that makes two news reports different even though the event was the same. Besides, for more newsworthy events with a greater national significance, reporters can be lined up for live discussions in each successive bulletin or can provide news updates so long as the story is ‘developing’ which could run into days. In that sense, a wire copy is often used as a first reaction and later the news organisations prefer to cover the events/happenings in their own style.

Activity 1

Pick up any day's newspaper. Read all the news and write their source. How many news are taken from news agencies? Write the names of those news agencies and write your observation on the importance of news agencies for a newspaper.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. What is the relevance of fact checking and verifications by reporters in the age of 24X7 news channels?

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2. What are the challenges faced by journalists during investigative news reportage?

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3. Discuss the importance of national and international news agencies.

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2.2.4 Individual Sources

Most news organisations insist on getting government or established sources of information to add weight to their stories. As discussed above, this is how media tend to reinforce the definition of the powerful few and impose a single meaning to the event. Stuart Hall's concept of the *primary definers* of news succinctly sums up this aspect of news. As a result of pressures of time and resource allocation coupled with the journalistic practice of objective and balanced reporting, reporters tend to get statements from ‘accredited sources’ i.e. accredited ‘representatives’ of powerful organisations who become what Hall calls the ‘primary definers of the topics’.

This initial framework sets the tone and parameters of the discussion on the given topic. In this way media reproduce the dominant ideas, the ideologies of the ruling class and are often in subordination to these powerful institutions in contradiction to the normative ideal of the press being a watchdog of society.

Besides the *institutional sources*, reporters often turn to subject ‘experts’, academics or known faces in a particular field to lend a new dimension to the story. For example a story on Women’s Reservation Bill will usually consist of interviews of at least two women MPs representing two different political parties in favor of the Bill and may be another woman MP against the Bill. In addition to these, the reporter must try and get a known women rights activists and a byte from the general public to flesh out the debate from different points of view. Neutral sources that do not have a direct stake in the issue provide the much-needed balance, but are often last in the priority of sources!

2.2.5 Online Sources and Social Media Platforms

Internet have radically altered the way news is collected, disseminated and consumed. The significance of the internet as a source of news is very well documented in the literature on online news and social media. Newspapers and TV news channels keep a track of what news items are posted on different news portals and websites on a daily basis. In the presentday digital world, Twitter (see Hermida 2010), Facebook and other social media platforms are emerging as instantaneous and popular sources of news with almost all politicians at national and international levels, political parties, organisations, and celebrities. Newsmakers having their own twitter accounts and Facebook pages directly connect with the public and feed reporters with the latest information.

2.3 RELIABILITY AND CREDIBILITY OF SOURCES

Journalistic practice relies on factual information. A news story normally is made up of interview bytes or ‘talking heads’ who give their accounts or comments on an event. A journalist’s job is to pad the story with the comments or bytes in a logical sequence and add voiceovers plus visuals so that the event can make sense to the audiences. The sources in that sense are the building blocks of the story. In routine practice of fast pace news production, reporters do not have the time or the resources to probe into the sources’ informational world to establish the legitimacy of the facts independent of the source’s account (Schlesinger 1978; Ericson, Baranek and Chan 1989).

Scholars have warned that journalism is increasingly accommodating funding and ownership patterns, work practices and routines that blur the distinction between fact and fiction, selling propaganda in the name of news. In such a scenario, many a times individual reporters find themselves torn between ethical principles they cherish, the foremost being truth telling and the pressures accruing from the corporate control of the press which dilutes such

a commitment.

Government sources, party spokespersons, ministers, officials and bureaucrats are considered to be authorised sources of information and the best talking heads to give credibility to a story. The suitability of sources is adjudged through a process of bureaucratized institutional form of authority and knowledge in which editors and sometimes the management decides who will be given space in the news story and which institutions, communities and individuals will be denied such privilege. This is also partly how news maintains social status quo, representing political power as residing in formal institutions of the state and law enforcement agencies keeping the poor and marginalised sections of society in the periphery. It is a clear categorisation between the haves and have-nots; the powerful and the voiceless (see Golding, Murdock, and Schlesinger 1986).

In the case of television news, visuals and footage from locations or showing the face of the eyewitness add credibility and a slice of reality to the story as the saying goes - seeing is believing. Besides, television story's construction also involves staging of sources complete with props, lighting, sound and realistic background to make the scene as close to reality as possible. Often the emphasis is on presentation than on the veracity of information. Moreover, with visual and high end graphics used in packaging less credible information or even false information are easily passed off as fact. Publishing news not attributable to any source or under the pretext of unidentified sources is indicative of low quality journalism which should be avoided at all cost.

In the last couple of years 'fake news' has emerged as a major social issue faced by citizens and governments alike. As the phenomenon of fake news becomes more widespread with platforms like WhatsApp providing easy avenue for their ready dissemination, new technologies and tools are being developed to detect fake news and ensure that citizens can ensure the veracity of information they consume (Zhou and Zafarani, 2018).

The onus lies with both news organisations as producers of information and citizens as consumers of information to push for truth telling in the public domain. This will not only ensure the criticality of information in the public sphere and its parallel strengthening of democracy but also serve to safeguard ethical principles that are definitive of journalism as we know it for hundreds of years (Saeed, 2013).

Check Your Progress 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Why should sources be credible in journalism ?

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2.4 LET US SUM UP

In the unit, we have discussed in detail the various sources that journalists use to report a news story. It recounts the history of the emergence and consolidation of international and national news agencies and how the wire copies have always served as a staple of news that feeds into newspapers and television. It further explores the other sources of information that reporters routinely turn to like interviewing individual newsmakers or reporting on events as they happen on the ground.

Usually official sources find a privileged place in news when compared to the less powerful and marginalised groups and communities. In doing so, news has traditionally served to mirror and maintain the social structures and differences including the biases in society instead of challenging these stereotypes and domination that favor the rich and the powerful. This major shortcoming of news is complicated in a digital era where fake news and misinformation is being peddled in the name of journalism. It posits a real danger to the future of journalism and democracy making it imperative that we develop tools and fact checkers that can detect fake news early enough to prevent its wide dissemination.

2.5 FURTHER READINGS

Gans, Herbert, (2004). *Deciding What's News*, 25th-anniversary edition, Northwestern University Press: Illinois

Saeed, Saima, (2013). *Screening the Public Sphere: Media and Democracy in India*, New Delhi and London: Routledge

Schudson, Michael, (1995). *The Power of News*, Harvard University Press: Massachusetts.

2.6 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS: POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

1. Fact checking and verification of news sources as well as content is crucial to create credible information. Audiences have become more skeptical of what they consume, so ethical journalism implies having timely and appropriate representation of facts.
2. Each news organisation subscribes to a large number of national and international news agencies to keep a close tab on all that is happening in different parts of the world

Check Your Progress 2

1. The credibility of sourcing is important in journalism as fake news posits a danger to democracy and journalism due to misinformation. There is a need to develop tools and fact checkers to detect fake news and prevent its wide dissemination. Credibility of news sources, especially, in digital world, is essential to check. Do not rely on WhatsApp, Wikipedia, or other commercial oriented websites so that fake news can be avoided.

UNIT 3 NEWS ROOM SET-UP AND FUNCTIONING OF PRINT MEDIA

Structure

- 3.0 Introduction
- 3.1 Learning Outcomes
- 3.2 Functions of a Newsroom
- 3.3 Newspaper : Editorial Structure
 - 3.3.1 News Wing
 - 3.3.2 Reporting Wing
 - 3.3.3 Photography Wing
 - 3.3.4 Desktop Publishing Wing
- 3.4 Newsroom of Magazines
- 3.5 Changing Pattern of Newsrooms
 - 3.5.1 Use of Digital Technology
- 3.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 3.7 Further Readings
- 3.8 Check Your Progress: Possible Answers

3.0 INTRODUCTION

This unit will delve into the newsroom set up and functions of print and online media. Newspapers that reach our homes every morning, goes through a complicated publication process which needs a professionally trained and experienced team. A team consisting of editorial and reporting staff completes various assignments including news gathering, news selection, news editing, page making and many more. All these activities, known as news processing, take place every day in a newsroom under tremendous pressure in order to meet the deadlines.

In true sense, a newspaper is made by its editorial and reporting team. They generally sit under one roof, i.e., the newsroom for completion of their tasks, starting from gathering news to publication and post publication processes. This unit will focus on the working mechanism of a newsroom and its function as well as the structural difference between a newspaper and magazine house.

3.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After going through this unit, you should be able to:

- discuss the functions of newsroom including news gathering, selection, editing and page making;
- describe the newsroom hierarchy and the responsibilities of journalists; and

- analyse the structural difference between newspaper and magazine.

3.2 FUNCTIONS OF A NEWSROOM

Journalists, reporters, editors, news anchors, designers, and other staff members who create and report news that is published, need a central place to operate. Newsroom is that particular central arena. Newsroom is the strategical common place where actual news operation takes place. It is the heart of a newspaper where information is processed into news and views. The editorial wing (also known as Editorial Department or Copy Desk or News Desk) and reporting wings are parts of the newsroom.

Generally, all editorial and reporting staff coordinates in the planning and processing of news. The newsroom is a constant busy space where various activities take place in three shifts - morning, afternoon and night. The first shift starts in the morning, when editor calls a meeting for analysis of news coverage and comparing it with the rival newspapers. In case of any factual errors and technical mistakes, these are pointed out and valuable inputs given for improvement. Then planning for news coverage is made and accordingly duties are assigned to the editorial and reporting staff. This brainstorming session gives useful guidance to the juniors how to avoid mistakes and maintain consistency in news coverage and presentation.

The afternoon session activates the editorial wing. All editorial staff, particularly the Sub/Copy Editor, Senior Sub/Copy Editor and Chief Sub/Copy Editor, starts the editing process under the guidance of News Editor. Initially it goes at a slow pace, but in the evening, news comes very fast and processed accordingly in order to meet deadline. Keeping in view the news values, this wing proposes lead news followed by other news items on various pages before the Editor. After multiple rounds of checking, it is finalised and then news goes on different pages for designing and publication. This entire process requires professional skills, team efforts and co-ordination at every level.

Newsroom plays a vital role in the making of a newspaper. In addition, some other activities have been merged with the newsroom which include - Desktop Publishing (typing, photo editing, illustration, page designing and its transmission etc.) which support the editorial and reporting staff in speedy processing. Thus, a newsroom undertakes the activities of news gathering, selection of news, editing, page layout and designing. Let us look at these activities in detail.

News Gathering: You have read in the previous unit that reporters are one of the main sources of news. They cover various beats and collect news. Thereafter, news is submitted to newsroom, where it is processed and put up in a presentable manner. The close coordination between the editing and reporting wing is very important in the process of news making and presentation.

News Selection: The next step is the selection of news. In a news organisation, a number of gatekeepers work at various points in the editing and reporting wings. Their duty is to select or reject information on the basis

of their news-worthiness. A reporter may draw upon his/her sources, reach the spot and make efforts to obtain information. However, each event and incident will not be newsworthy and a few stories get selected for making news. Even the reporter has to reject some events/incidents, which do not have news value.

News Editing: Editing is the final point of a newsroom, where a sub/copy editor examines the news value of the news story and edits it in order to make it readable. S/he reads all news stories carefully, edits and fine tunes the news items and reads it again. A sub editor follows the editing methods such as arranging, adding, reducing and translating the facts and gives a readable shape including a headline to the news items. The gatekeeping process continues at the level of editing too. The Sub/copy editor may reject the news story, if it is not relevant for larger audience and does not contain news values.

Page Designing and Layout: Presentation and arrangement of a newspaper is very important for attracting readers and that is why news organisations are doing extensive research on content presentation and implementing the findings. The presentation as per editorial and graphical guidelines includes placement of news by order of importance, use of logos, illustrations and graphics and most importantly; style sheet that covers font, colour, box and pointers etc. In totality, page designing and layout covers all these aspects and the same are finalised by newsroom staff. The placement of advertisements should be such that it does not obstruct any news but still gain visibility. Now-a-days, Desktop Publishing (DTP) operators have become extremely important and are in great demand.

Activity 1

Create a flowchart to show the activities carried out in the newsroom of a newspaper.

Check Your Progress 1

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1. Briefly describe the functions that are performed in a newsroom.

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3.3 NEWSPAPER : EDITORIAL STRUCTURE

Every day, newspapers publish large chunks of stories and a crucial aspect of the publishing process is the editorial department which is responsible for news interpretation, selection, and release. The editorial structure of a newspaper organisation constitutes a variety of professional staff at different levels, as discussed below:

Editor/Chief Editor/Editor-in-Chief: An experienced and visionary professional who heads a newspaper organisation is known as the Editor or Chief Editor or Editor-in-Chief. S/he supervises and controls all the newsrooms that come under his/her authority across the country. The designation varies according to the size and structure of the newspaper. The person is actively involved in the planning and growth of newspaper and being the head of the news wing, s/he is responsible for everything particularly the editorial page, which is considered to be the voice of a newspaper. S/he writes editorial and special comments on contemporary issues from time to time. To summarise the responsibilities of the editor in chief, they ensure uniformity and stability, they check for precision, as well as ensure planning strategies and overall functioning of a newspaper.

Executive Editor: As the name suggests, Executive Editor executes the vision of the Editor-in-Chief into reality. S/he sets the tone of the newspaper as well as takes part in all initiatives taken by the Chief Editor and accordingly gives suggestions to the junior staff. In the absence of the Editor-in-Chief, s/he looks after all the activities of the newsroom. They coordinate several or all aspects of the production process as well.

Resident Editor: In the case of multi-edition newspapers published from different cities/towns/capitals, a person who heads that particular edition is known as Resident Editor. For example, The Times of India originates from Mumbai, but its other editions are from New Delhi, Kolkata, Patna and Chandigarh etc. Similarly, The Hindustan Times originates from New Delhi, but its editions are in Mumbai, Chandigarh, Patna, Lucknow etc. In Hindi newspapers, Dainik Jagran, Dainik Bhaskar, Hindustan have more than 30 editions across the country which are led by the Resident Editors. Thus Resident Editor serves as extended arms of the Chief Editor, who implements the newspaper's policies and is responsible for the selection and publication of news and views for the local editions. S/he heads the local editorial and reporting wing of a newspaper.

Assistant Editor: The Assistant Editor assists the chief editor and performs the duties assigned by the chief editor. This may be writing an editorial, looking after the feature page, supporting the editor with delivery of manuscript and any other admin help required. S/he is the key person, who is closely associated with the chief editor.

News Editor: The News Editor is a key person in newsroom, who supervises the news content of every edition. They decide the selection and rejection of news items and assigns it on various pages. S/he also gives a fresh treatment or angle to the news, if the story has the elements of news-worthiness. Apart from this, s/he allocates news to different pages on the basis of its importance and supervises his/her colleagues at different levels such as news placement and page designing etc. S/he is always in close contact with the news and reporting wing for better co-ordination. The news editor knows the policies, legal and ethical issues of the organization and implements the same under the guidance of the editor. The post of news editor exists in all big newspapers, but in small and medium newspapers, the chief sub editor performs the duties of news editor.

Chief Sub/Copy Editor: The Chief Sub Editor, also known as Chief Sub, performs all the duties of news operation with the help of senior sub editor and sub editors. S/he distributes news items to sub editor for editing and pages for designing. Further, s/he also decides the treatment or angle and length and breadth of news story. S/he remains in close contact with the junior staff and coordinates with them. S/he coordinates with news and reporting wing for better coverage and also consults with the advertisement and circulation wing.

Senior Sub/Copy Editor: For smooth functioning of the newsroom and to assist the chief sub editor; the senior sub editor mediates between the chief sub editor and sub editors. S/he ensures accuracy, objectivity and balance in news processing for avoiding mistakes during pressure hours.

Sub/Copy Editor: The sub editor, also called as copy editor plays a crucial role in the publication of a newspaper. S/he actively engages oneself in various works such as news editing, processing and page designing etc. during pressure hours. A sub editor performs various duties such as: editing and rewriting a news story with an impressive intro in an inverted pyramid form; checking for any grammatical errors; giving pointers to a news item; caption to a photo; and translating news item. In doing so, s/he keeps the available space in view and ensures proper placement of story and designing on the assigned page and proof reading.

Trainee: A trainee is a newcomer who joins a newspaper just after the completion of his/her professional degree. In order to understand the working mechanism of a newsroom, s/he is put in association with a sub editor, where s/he learns the basic principles of news editing and page designing. S/he also seeks guidance from the senior members regarding the functioning of a newsroom.

3.3.1 News Wing

News Desk is the central wing, where actual news operation takes place. In addition there are some specialised desks where niche work is done such as Business Desk, Sports Desk, Foreign Desk, Film Desk, Desk for Sunday Magazine and Special Pages. These desks work independently from Central Editing Desk.

The Business Desk plans and executes the coverage of share market, entrepreneurship, financial activities and business news etc. The Sports Desk plans and executes the coverage of sports activities. The Foreign Desk plans and executes the coverage of international developments, foreign visits of President, Prime Minister and other prominent leaders and its impact etc. The Film Desk plans the coverage of film release and its review, celebrity gossips, profile of a film star etc. Sunday Magazine and Special Pages are planned and published by newspaper on any particular day like Sunday, Saturday etc.

Check Your Progress: 2

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Why is news editor considered a key person in a newsroom? Who all reports to the news editor?

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2) How is a resident editor different than an executive editor?

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3.3.2 Reporting Wing

The Reporting Wing is the main source of information for newsroom as it supplies news items on a daily basis. It not only reports news items, but also promotes a newspaper as a brand. In fact, both the wings are interdependent, but the charm of reporting makes a huge difference. The following are the various categories of reporters who work in a newspaper:

Bureau Chief: The Bureau Chief is a key person who leads central bureau from where a newspaper is being published. S/he leads a group of reporting staff and assigns them duties. S/he co-ordinates with news wing in consultation with the news editor or chief sub editor and also reports major developments to the editor. S/he also leads local bureau offices where newspaper's circulation and news fall is substantial. These bureaus are extended branch of a newspaper house from where all the activities of the newspaper are performed.

Special Correspondents: They are the senior and most experienced members of the editorial wing who cover crucial political and economic issues. The matters of national and international importance such as foreign visit of President or Prime Minister, cabinet meeting called by Prime Minister or Chief Minister as well as parliamentary and legislative sessions are generally covered by the special correspondents.

Chief Reporter: The Chief Reporter covers major events in the city or district and assigns duties to all the reporters and guides them. S/he also plans special stories, work with multiple communities, and develops one's information sources at various levels so that one can report incidents in a timely manner. The Chief reporter keeps close contacts with the chief sub editor for better coordination of the city edition.

Senior Reporter: Senior Reporter also covers major happenings in the city and assists the bureau chief and chief reporter in smooth functioning of news

coverage. They specialize in certain specific areas such as sports, war, crime, etc. They also assess the news worthiness and manages the process of content creation.

Reporter: A group of reporters work in the newspaper. They have specific coverage area according to their ability and expertise which is judged by the editor. This specific area is called beat. If a reporter is interested in politics, s/he gets a chance to do political beat. They are supervised and instructed by the bureau chief or the chief reporter to file news items on time.

Stringer: Since it is not financially viable to recruit reporters in each city and area, a newspaper house appoints a group of stringers for coverage of various areas. They provide news items from their specific areas. They are usually part-time employees of a newspaper, but they provide news on a regular basis and are paid according to the size or words written in the story.

In addition to the above listed roles, there are some other sources that provide news items to a newspaper such as News Agencies, Press Release, Hand-outs and Press Communiques issued by the different organisations.

News Agencies: News Agencies are the main source of bulk supply of news materials including feature and photographs. Most of the newspapers take the services of news agencies like Press Trust of India (PTI), United News of India (UNI) and Indo-Asian News Service (IANS).

These news agencies have international collaborations too. PTI has tied up with Agence France Presse (AFP), Associated Press (AP) and The New York Times, while UNI has tied up with Reuters, Xinhua, Deutsche Presse Agentur (DPA) etc. Some Hindi news agencies are PTI (Bhasha), Univarta, Hindustan Samachar and Samachar Bharti etc.

3.3.3 Photography Wing

The photography wing has prominent position in a newspaper. Most of the newspapers have made it necessary to put a photo or logo or cartoon (small or big depending on the size of a story) along with news items. The big, medium and small newspapers appoint a photography team led by Photo Editor. The following are the members of the wing:

Photo Editor: Photo Editor is the head of photography wing who is experienced and creative enough to select best photos for newspapers in consultation with the editor. While selecting a photo, s/he keeps news sense in mind and positions photos in sync with news items. S/he also assigns duties to the colleagues for photo coverage and sometimes takes photos from news agencies and photo library of the organisation for effective presentation.

Chief Photographer: Chief Photographer is the second in command in photography wing, who captures and processes photos of various news items. Generally, s/he covers visit of a local politician or celebrity, public meetings, cultural programmes, demonstrations, fairs, exhibitions and accidents etc.

Photographer: A big newspaper generally recruits a good photography team with specialization in various areas such as sports, wildlife, art and culture and political photography. Photographers are assigned duties on the basis of

their specialization by either photo editor or chief photographer. They photograph various events, people, places and submits it to the newsroom with good captions.

3.3.4 Desktop Publishing Wing

This wing provides technical support to the newspaper. It designs illustration, logo and caricature for a news story and also provides font size, colour, ad design and other materials in consultation with the editor. The staff of Desktop Publishing (DTP) are not journalists, but with experience, training and close coordination with sub editors they acquire basic journalistic skills. This wing is led by Chief Desktop Publishing Operator.

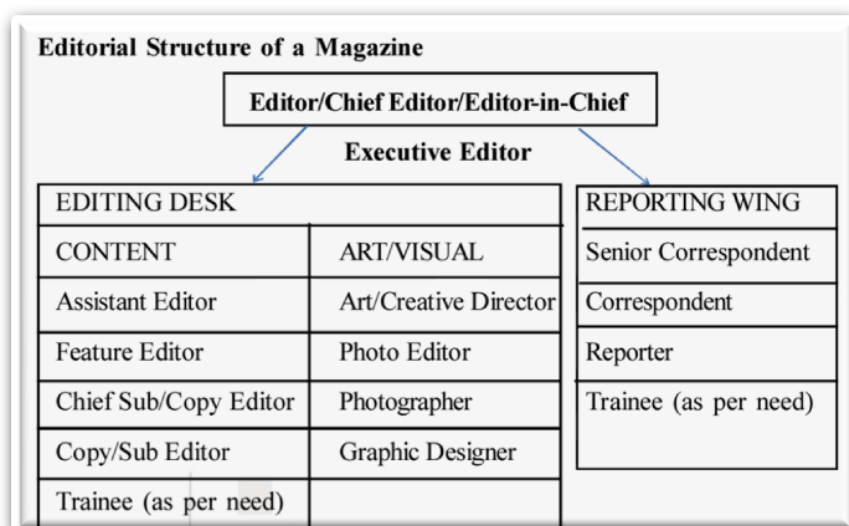
Desktop Publishing in Charge: Chief DTP Operator leads technical wing and supervises all staff to work with close coordination with news wing. S/he assigns various duties such as designing a page, logo, illustrations, font to DTP Operators. They aim to create high quality material that comprises of text and images. DTP wing is the final place where a page is checked technically and goes for publication. Therefore, s/he ensures that newspaper should reach the printing press on time.

Layout artists and graphic designers also comprise the DTP wing and are mainly responsible for making pages attractive. The designers take ideas from sub editors regarding news placement and then design the page with their aesthetic sense.

3.4 NEWSROOM OF MAGAZINES

It will be worthwhile to briefly look at the newsroom of magazines which is totally different from that of a newspaper due to the difference in their periodicity, size, and content. A magazine is published in a digest or journal form while a newspaper comes up in broadsheet or tabloid. The periodicity of a magazine may be weekly, fortnightly, monthly, quarterly, even half yearly etc., while a newspaper comes up on a daily or weekly basis.

Moreover, the content of a newspaper mainly focuses on daily happenings that provide information in inverted pyramid style, but magazine covers any event for a long period, based on research.



Keeping above factors in view, a magazine needs a small newsroom set up. The number of staff is lesser than a newspaper and varies from one magazine set up to another.

Check Your Progress: 3

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

1) Give an overview of the editorial structure of a magazine.

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2) Why is photography wing essential in a newspaper?

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3.5 CHANGING PATTERNS OF NEWS ROOMS

The use of Information and Communication Technology (ICT) has changed the face of newsrooms. The newsrooms are turning digital, and the acceptance became normalized for workers and readers majorly during the period of Covid lockdown. It has become very easy to cross-check facts through internet, modify news selection, rejection and placement process through various software like Word Pro, News Pro and Word Xpress etc. It is also possible to break the designed page and redesign it through software like Lucidpress (Marq), In-Design, Page Maker etc.

A visual can also be used or modified by many ways with the help of software such as Adobe Photoshop etc. A designed page, visual and news material can easily be sent from one place to another with advanced digital technology. It can also be sent directly for publication from the newsroom.

3.5.1 Use of Digital Technology

It is hardly surprising that it is compulsory for all, irrespective of their position, to be well acquainted with the latest and changing technologies. The traditional newsroom was totally based on 'Pen-Paper Work' wherein the process of transmission of news was cumbersome as compared with today's newsroom setup.

The following electronic tools have become essential for the present day newsroom:

- **Computers, Internet and Modem:** Internet has become essential in every newsroom now-a-days. It not only helps in cross-checking the facts, but also transmits news and photographs in fraction of seconds. A designed page can easily be sent from the headquarters to the local centres and vice versa for publication of newspaper through electronic devices.

- Software: Some software are commonly used for news editing like News Pro, Word Pro and Word Xpress, while Adobe Photoshop for photo editing while Quark Xpress, In-Design, Canva, Lucidpress, and Page Maker etc. are used for page designing.

Despite all these technological developments notebooks, a pen or pencil and tape recorder have still maintained their importance in the era of paperless journalism.

Check Your Progress: 4

Note: 1) Use the space below for you answers.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this unit.

- 1) Which new technological advancements have changed the face of a newsroom?

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3.6 LET US SUM UP

We have discussed the newsroom set up of a newspaper and the professional staff working at various levels in this unit. It was discussed that the publication of a newspaper is a complicated activity which needs a professionally trained team. A team consisting of editorial and reporting staff completes various functions of newsroom such as news gathering, gate-keeping, news editing and page making etc. under the leadership of the Editor-in-Chief. Collectively these activities are known as news processing. The content and presentation of a newspaper reflects the vision of the Editor who is assisted by a team of professionals including sub-editor, assistant editor, resident editor, and many more.

It was also discussed that the publication of a magazine is different from a newspaper because of its periodicity, size and content. It needs a small newsroom set up led by the editor.

3.7 FURTHER READINGS

Raman Usha, 2019. Writing for Media, Oxford Publication.

SK Bansal, 2009. Information Technology in Journalism, APH Publishing Corporation.

Spark David, 2010. Harris Geoffrey, Practical Newspaper Reporting, Sage (fourth Edition)

3.8 CHECK YOUR PROGRESS : POSSIBLE ANSWERS

Check Your Progress 1

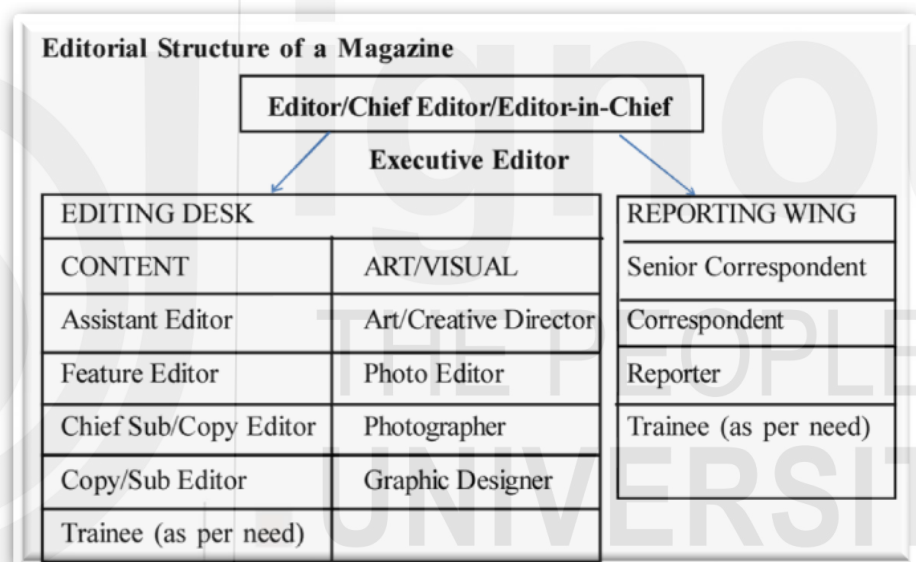
1. News Gathering; News Selection; News Editing; Page Designing & Layout

Check Your Progress 2

1. The News Editor is a key person in newsroom, who supervises the news content of every edition. They decide the selection and rejection of news items and assigns it on various pages. S/he also gives a fresh treatment or angle to the news, if the story has the elements of news-worthiness. Apart from this, s/he allocates news to different pages on the basis of its importance. Chief sub/copy editor followed by Senior sub/copy editor, Sub/copy editor, and trainee are the ones who report to the News Editor.
2. The Executive editor executes editorial plans and policies for all editions, whereas Resident Editor focuses on a single edition. The Executive editor provides key suggestions to Chief Editor for the growth of multi-edition newspapers, whereas Resident Editor contributes for this growth from single edition located in a particular city/town.

Check Your Progress 3

1.



2. The photography wing has prominent position in a newspaper. Most of the newspapers have made it necessary to put a photo or logo or cartoon (small or big depending on the size of a story) along with news items. Photo editor and chief photographer followed by photographers are an essential part of the team.

Check Your Progress 4

1. i. Computers, Internet and Modem: Internet has become essential in every newsroom now-a-days. It not only helps in cross-checking the facts, but also transmits news and photographs in fraction of seconds.
- ii. Software: Some software are commonly used for news editing like News Pro, Word Pro and Word Xpress, while Adobe Photoshop for photo editing while Quark Xpress, In-Design, Canva, Lucidpress, and Page Maker etc. are used for page designing.